

18 Things Every Veteran Should Know

You earned a wide range of benefits — health care, disability pay, education, home loans, and more — and many veterans never claim all of them. Below are the key starting points, all free. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Free, accredited help (a VSO) can file your claims at no cost — never pay a company to “get your benefits.” Start with VA.gov or the VA hotline at 1-800-827-1000, and a VSO for claims.

1 Start Here

Your two best free entry points to everything VA.

- ☐ **VA.gov — Your Benefits Hub**
Apply for and manage health care, disability, education, and more in one place.
→ www.va.gov 1-800-827-1000
- ☐ **Get Free Help From a VSO**
Accredited Veterans Service Officers file your claims for free. Find one near you.
→ www.va.gov/get-help-from-accredited-representative

2 Health & Disability

Coverage and tax-free monthly pay you may have earned.

- ☐ **VA Health Care**
Enroll for low- or no-cost health care, including toxic-exposure care under the PACT Act.
→ www.va.gov/health-care
- ☐ **VA Disability Compensation**
Tax-free monthly pay for service-connected conditions. See the Disability guide.
→ www.va.gov/disability

3 Education, Home & Money

Big-ticket benefits worth tens of thousands.

- ☐ **GI Bill & Education**
Pay for school, training, or certifications. See the Education guide.
→ www.va.gov/education
- ☐ **VA Home Loan**
Buy a home with zero down and no PMI. See the Housing guide.
→ www.va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans
- ☐ **VA Pension (Low-Income)**
Tax-free income for wartime veterans with limited income, including Aid & Attendance.
→ www.va.gov/pension

4 In Crisis or Need? Free Help Now

Immediate support for tough times.

☐ Veterans Crisis Line

Free, confidential 24/7 support. Dial 988 then press 1, or text 838255.

→ www.veteranscrisisline.net 988 then press 1

☐ Homeless & Emergency Help

Free VA help if you're homeless or at risk. Call the National Call Center for Homeless Veterans.

→ www.va.gov/homeless 1-877-424-3838

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never pay a company a fee or a cut of your back pay to file a VA claim — using an accredited VSO is free, and charging for claim prep is often illegal. Be wary of “claim sharks.”

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

File an “intent to file” on VA.gov as soon as you think you may have a claim — it locks in an earlier start date for back pay while you gather evidence with a VSO.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national benefits. For your nearest VSO, VA medical center, and state veteran benefits, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll connect you.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
